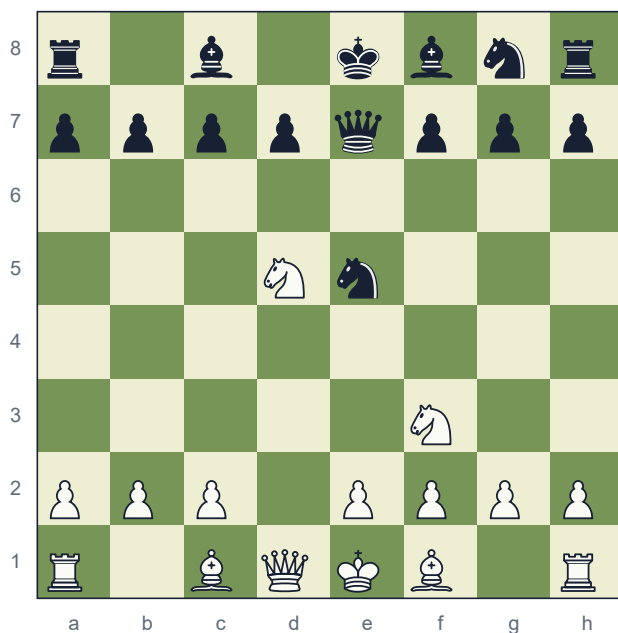


When c4 waits: Englund and unusual first moves

1.d4 e5, 1...c5, 1...Nc6, 1...b6 and 1...b5

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Respond to what Black has actually offered. Against a direct attack on d4 or a free central pawn, a central capture or advance can be more useful than automatic c4.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

These first moves may produce an open center, a closed Benoni, or a broad d4-e4 center. c4 remains a tool you can add later when it improves the position.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Unusual openings often rely on traps, an unfamiliar pawn structure, or a developing move gained by attacking an exposed queen.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. After 1...e5, choose 2.dxe5 rather than drifting into a needless pawn sacrifice with 2.c4.
2. After 1...c5, 2.d5 is the practical course choice; 2.c4 is not inherently losing.
3. Against ...b6 or ...b5, e4 takes offered central space; against ...e6 or ...c6, c4 remains a normal sound choice.

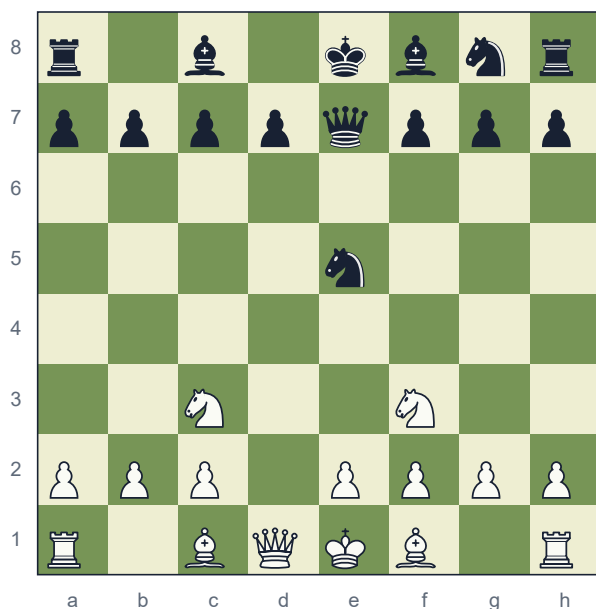
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Englund: develop against ...Qe7

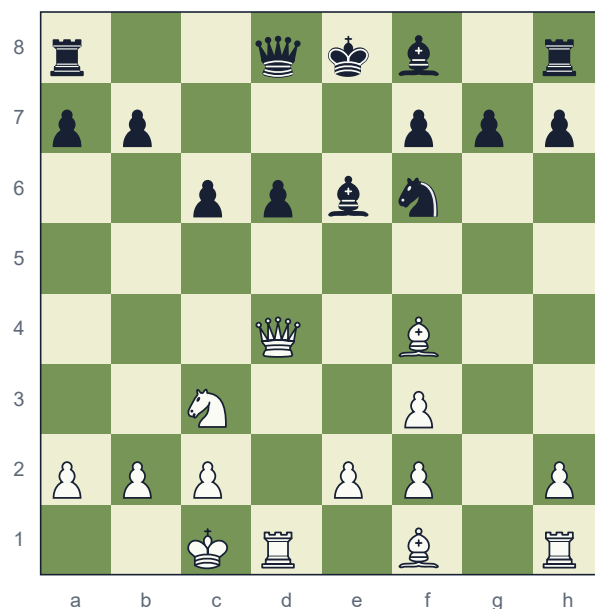
STUDY LINE 21-01

1. d4 e5 2. dxe5 Nc6 3. Nf3 Qe7 4. Nc3 Nxe5 5. Nd5 Nxf3+ 6. gxf3 Qd8 7. Bf4 d6 8. Qd4 c6 9. Nc3 Be6 10. O-O-O Nf6

Selected anchor ends with 5. Nd5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Nc3 develops while defending the center. After ...Nxe5, Nd5 attacks the queen with tempo and disrupts Black's intended setup.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Continue with useful developing moves and keep the king safe. If Black exchanges on f3 with check, recapture accurately and reevaluate the structure.

WATCH FOR

Do not play Bf4 and Qd2 mechanically against queen checks on b4. The queen's path and the b2 pawn matter.

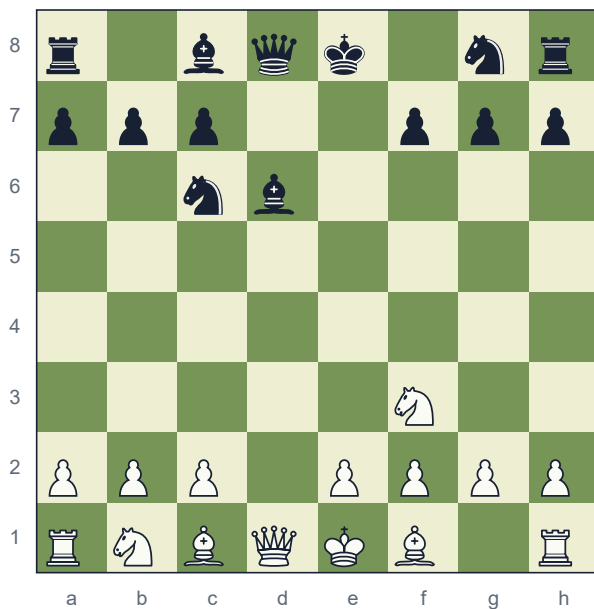
REMEMBER Meet the queen sortie with development and tempo.

02 Englund: the ...d6 gambit

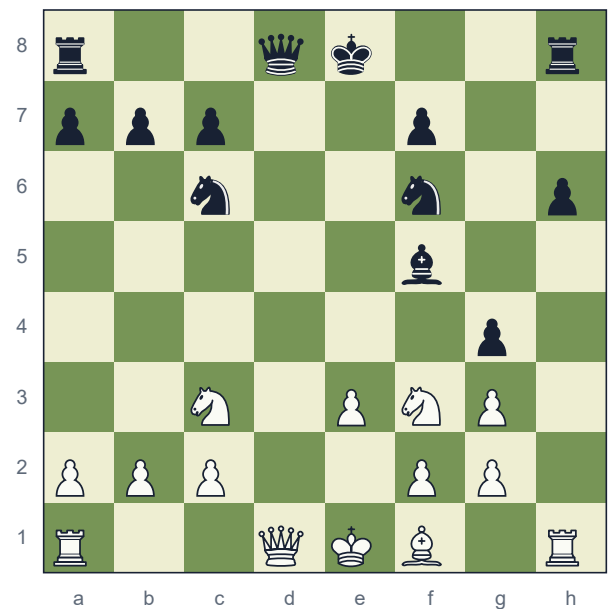
STUDY LINE 21-02

1. d4 e5 2. dxe5 Nc6 3. Nf3 d6 4. exd6 Bxd6 5. Nc3 Nf6 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 Bf5 8. e3 g5 9. Bg3 Bxg3 10. hxg3 g4

Selected anchor ends with 5... Nf6. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White accepts material but helps Black develop a bishop. Your response must be efficient development, not further pawn collecting.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bg5, e3 and king safety are natural aims. Return a pawn if it removes an initiative or opens a useful line for your pieces.

WATCH FOR

A knight move to e4 can come with threats against both bishops and central squares.

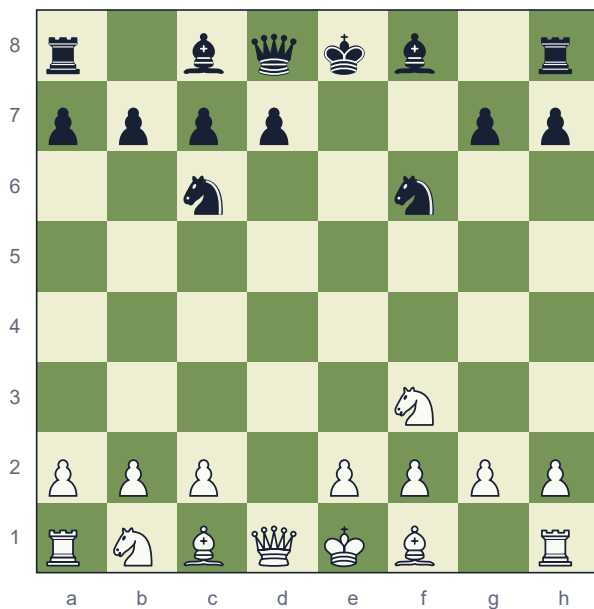
REMEMBER A gambit is answered with coordination as well as material.

03 Englund: the ...f6 gambit

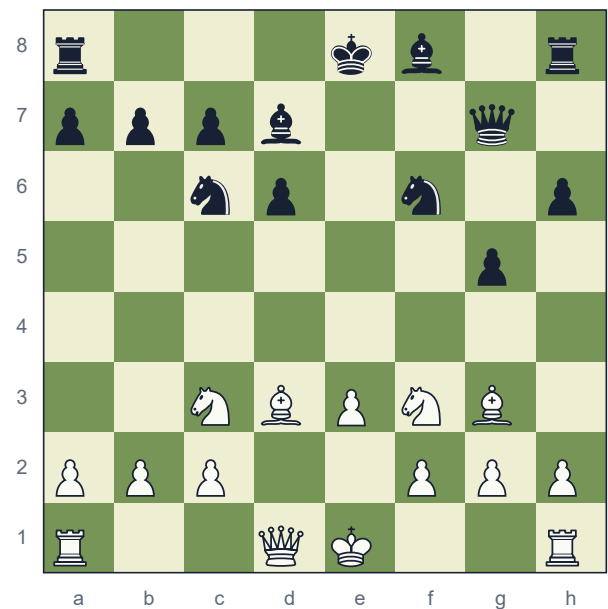
STUDY LINE 21-03

1. d4 e5 2. dxe5 Nc6 3. Nf3 f6 4. exf6 Nxf6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bh4 g5 7. Bg3 Qe7 8. e3 d6 9. Bd3 Qg7 10. Nc3 Bd7

Selected anchor ends with 5. Bg5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The f-pawn exchange leaves Black with an exposed king structure. Bg5 develops and increases pressure against f6.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Use e3, develop the bishops and castle. Look for central opening moves only when your pieces can use them.

WATCH FOR

Do not launch a queen raid before bringing out the rest of your pieces.

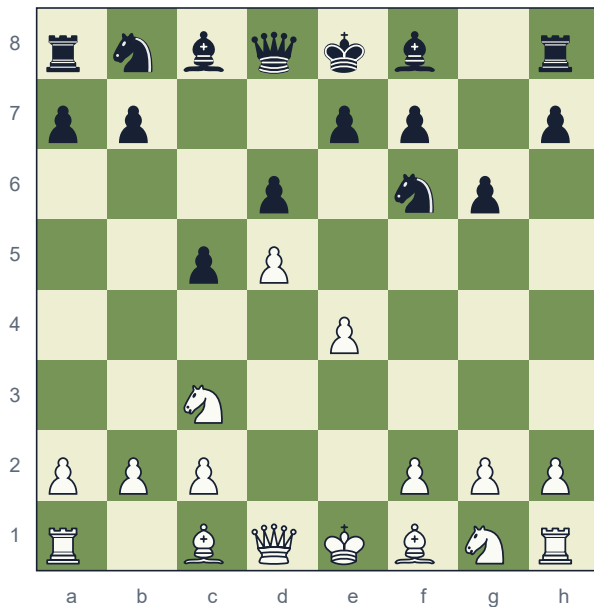
REMEMBER Use the weakened king structure through development.

04 1...c5: advance before playing c4

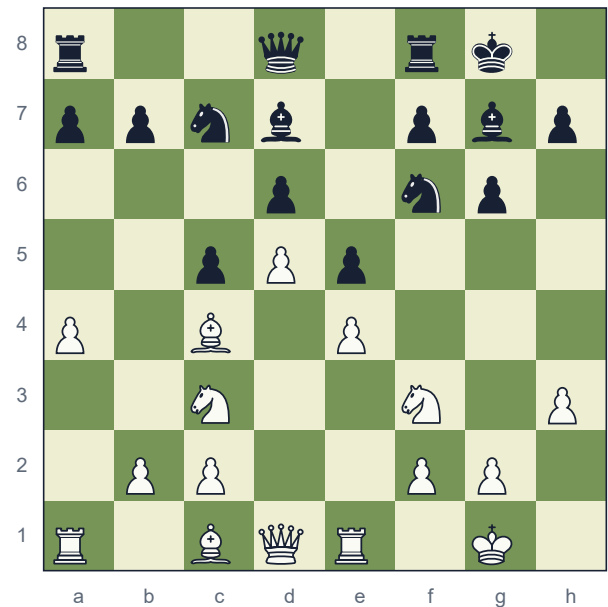
STUDY LINE 21-04

1. d4 c5 2. d5 Nf6 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 g6 5. Nf3 Bg7 6. Bc4 O-O 7. O-O Na6 8. h3 Nc7 9. Re1 Bd7 10. a4 e5

Selected anchor ends with 5... Bg7. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

d5 claims space immediately. Nc3 and e4 build the center; you are not required to add c4 to justify playing 1.d4.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Be2 and castle, or use another coherent king setup. If you later play c4, check whether it restricts useful knight routes.

WATCH FOR

Do not confuse a recommended practical move order with a statement that 2.c4 is a mistake.

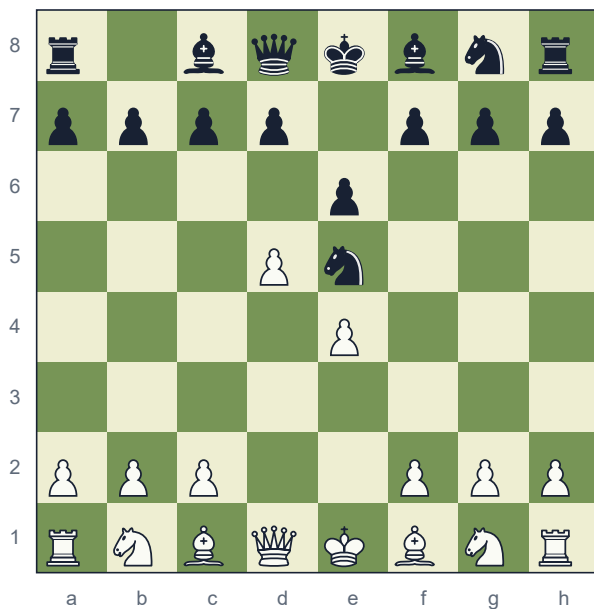
REMEMBER Take the offered space and build behind it.

05 1...Nc6: gain space with d5

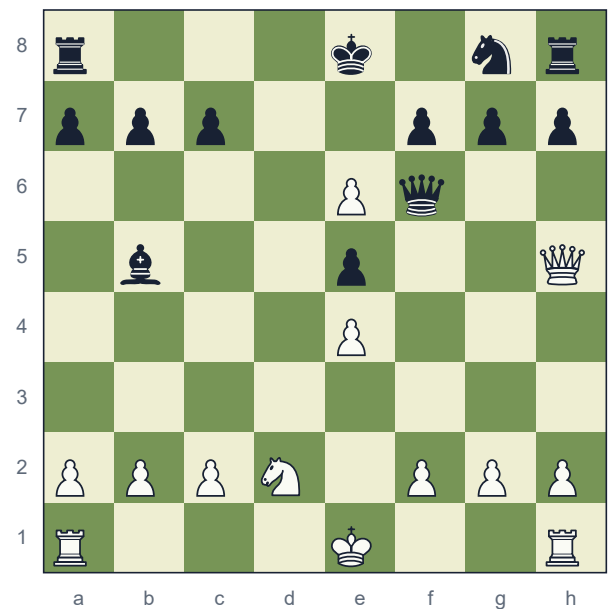
STUDY LINE 21-05

1. d4 Nc6 2. d5 Ne5 3. e4 e6 4. Nf3 d6 5. Nxe5 dxe5 6. Bb5+ Bd7 7. dxe6 Bxb5 8. Qh5 Bb4+ 9. Bd2 Bxd2+ 10. Nxd2 Qf6

Selected anchor ends with 4. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 3 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

d5 gains time against the knight and e4 supports a broad center. Nf3 develops rather than using too many pawn moves to chase the knight.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the bishops and castle. Exchange centrally if that improves activity or reduces the chance of overextension.

WATCH FOR

A sequence of f-pawn and g-pawn pushes can expose the king while Black catches up in development.

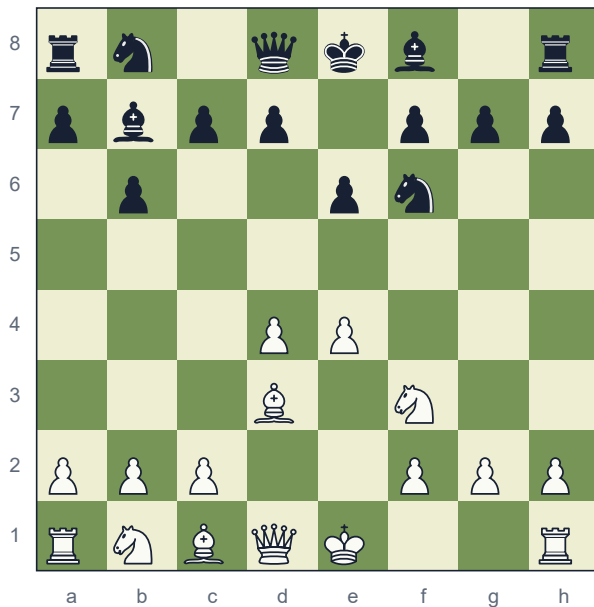
REMEMBER Gain space once, then develop.

06 1...b6: take e4

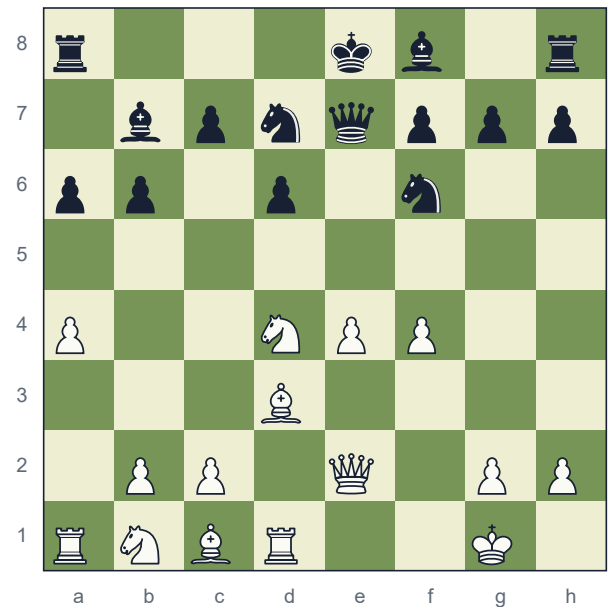
STUDY LINE 21-06

1. d4 b6 2. e4 Bb7 3. Bd3 e6 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. Qe2 d6 6. O-O Nbd7 7. Rd1 e5 8. a4 exd4 9. Nxd4 a6 10. f4 Qe7

Selected anchor ends with 5. Qe2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e4 uses the central space Black offered; Bd3 and Qe2 support it against the b7 bishop and f6 knight.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Castle and develop the b1 knight without blocking the pieces you need. Be ready for ...c5 or ...d5.

WATCH FOR

The bishop on b7 is already aimed at e4. Support the pawn before spending tempi on the flanks.

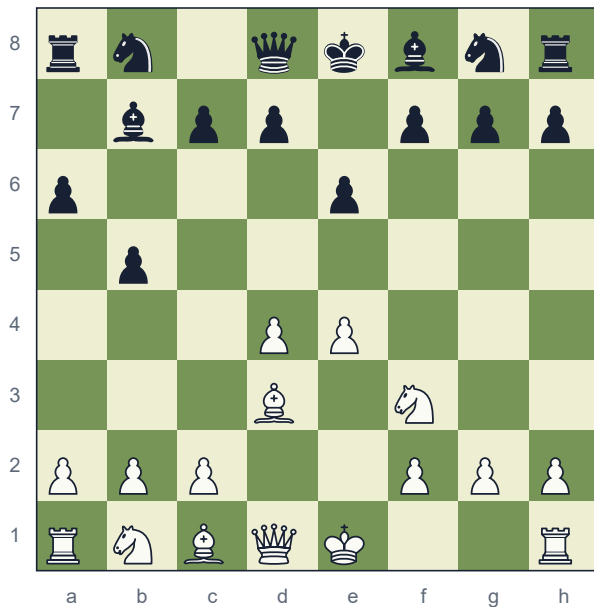
REMEMBER Take the center, then defend it with pieces.

07 1...b5: center before flank action

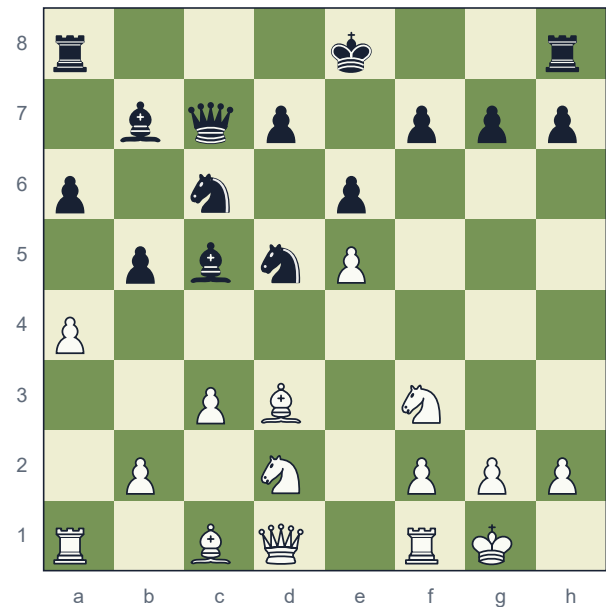
STUDY LINE 21-07

1. d4 b5 2. e4 Bb7 3. Bd3 a6 4. Nf3 e6 5. O-O c5 6. c3 Nf6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. e5 Nd5 9. Nbd2 Nc6 10. a4 Qc7

Selected anchor ends with 5. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White occupies the center while Black expands on the flank. The b5 pawn does not have to be attacked immediately.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

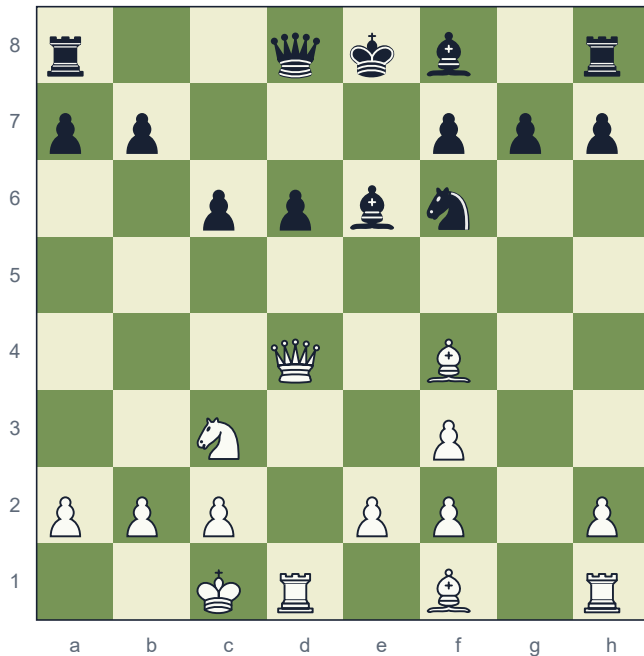
Develop Nc3 or Nbd2 as appropriate, then use a4 or central action if it improves your position.

WATCH FOR

Do not trade useful central pawns simply to win a flank pawn that cannot be held.

REMEMBER A flank opening is often answered in the center.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

These first moves may produce an open center, a closed Benoni, or a broad d4-e4 center. c4 remains a tool you can add later when it improves the position.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Unusual openings often rely on traps, an unfamiliar pawn structure, or a developing move gained by attacking an exposed queen.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Continue with useful developing moves and keep the king safe. If Black exchanges on f3 with check, recapture accurately and reevaluate the structure.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.